

A non-Brahmin priest at the Samayapuram Mariamman temple near Trichy making an offering to a *murti* (image) of the goddess made of sand and clay.

Besides these simple country shrines, the Mother Goddess also has a number of major temples devoted to her worship in Tamil Nadu, one of them being the Punainallur Mariamman temple in Thanjavur, built by a Maratha ruler in the 1680s following a dream in which Mariamman appeared to him and told him to look in a particular grove outside the city. There the raja found the deity in the form of a white anthill, around which he built the temple. As an unbeliever, I have to say that it was a disappointment after the